

Flood Survival and Evacuation Guide

This guide tells you exactly what to do before, during, and after a flood. It is written for survivors, not planners. Sourced from FEMA, NDMA, CDC, and National Weather Service guidelines.

THE NUMBER ONE RULE: Turn Around, Don't Drown. Just 15 centimetres (6 inches) of fast-moving floodwater can knock an adult off their feet. 30 centimetres (12 inches) can sweep away a car. Never walk or drive through floodwater.

SECTION 1: WHEN TO EVACUATE — IMMEDIATELY

Leave immediately — do not wait to see if the water reaches you — if ANY of the following are true:

1. Authorities have issued an evacuation order for your area.
2. You live in a low-lying area, near a river, or in a basement apartment.
3. Water is already rising around your building.
4. You hear emergency sirens or flood warnings.
5. You have received an emergency SMS or alert on your phone.

DO NOT WAIT. Most flood deaths occur because people underestimate the speed at which water rises. It can go from ankle-deep to chest-deep in minutes. Early evacuation is always safer than late evacuation.

SECTION 2: BEFORE LEAVING — WHAT TO DO IN 5 MINUTES

If you have time before evacuating (5 minutes or less):

1. Grab your emergency bag if you have one: water, medicine, phone charger, documents, torch, food.
2. Take essential medicines. This is the most important item — you cannot get prescription medication in a flood shelter easily.
3. Take your phone and power bank.
4. Turn off electricity at the main switch if you can do so safely and quickly. Do NOT go into a flooded area to reach an electrical panel.
5. Inform someone (family member, neighbour) of where you are going.
6. Do NOT waste time collecting valuables, appliances, or furniture. Nothing is worth your life.

SECTION 3: EVACUATING ON FOOT

Step 1. Walk to higher ground using the safest available route. Do not take shortcuts through low-lying areas.

Step 2. Do not walk through floodwater, even if it appears shallow. Floodwater hides hazards: open manholes, washed-away road surfaces, submerged debris, live electrical wires, and strong currents.

Step 3. If you must cross moving water on foot and there is no other option, use a long stick to test the ground ahead of each step. Face upstream. Move sideways, one step at a time.

Step 4. Never attempt to swim through floodwater unless it is your only option for survival. The current is always stronger than it looks, and debris can cause serious injury.

Step 5. If you are swept into floodwater, float on your back with your feet pointed downstream. This protects your head from impact with obstacles. Work your way toward the edge of the current.

SECTION 4: EVACUATING BY CAR

Step 1. Do not drive through flooded roads. If you cannot see the road surface under the water, do not drive on it. The road may have washed away entirely.

Step 2. A car can be swept away in just 30 centimetres (12 inches) of moving water. Large SUVs and trucks require only 45 to 60 centimetres (18 to 24 inches).

Step 3. If your vehicle stalls in floodwater: Get out immediately. Do not try to restart the engine. Leave the vehicle and move to higher ground.

Step 4. If water is rising rapidly inside your vehicle and you cannot open the door due to water pressure: Open the window immediately while the car is still partially above water. Electric windows may still work briefly. If windows will not open, use a hard object to break the side window — side windows are weaker than the windshield.

Step 5. Once out of the vehicle, move away from it immediately. Cars can shift, roll, or be pushed by the current.

Step 6. Follow official evacuation routes only. Do not follow shortcuts — they may be blocked or flooded.

SECTION 5: IF YOU ARE TRAPPED AND CANNOT EVACUATE

If water is rising and you cannot safely leave the building:

Step 1. Move to the highest floor of the building immediately. Do not go to a closed attic — you may become trapped as water rises with no way out.

Step 2. If you go to an attic, make sure it has a window or hatch you can climb through to get onto the roof if needed.

Step 3. Call emergency services (112) immediately and give your exact address or location.

Step 4. If you cannot make a phone call, send an SMS with your location. SMS messages can often get through when voice calls cannot.

Step 5. Signal for rescue from a window or roof: Wave a brightly coloured cloth, use a torch or phone screen to signal at night, or blow a whistle in three blasts (the international distress signal).

Step 6. Stay in one place and wait. Moving through deep floodwater to reach rescuers is more dangerous than staying put.

Step 7. Do not go onto the roof unless water is rising inside and you have no other option.

ELECTRICITY DANGER: Floodwater and electricity are a lethal combination. Do not touch electrical switches, appliances, or wiring if there is water around them. Do not walk in floodwater near electrical equipment. Electrical current can travel through water and kill at a distance.

SECTION 6: AFTER THE FLOOD — RETURNING HOME

Return home only when authorities say it is safe to do so. Never return early — the building may be structurally damaged and floodwater may still be electrically charged.

Step 1. Before entering the building, check for structural damage from the outside. Look for cracks in the foundation, leaning walls, or a damaged roof. Do not enter if the building looks unstable.

Step 2. Do not turn electricity back on until the building has been inspected and declared safe by an electrician.

Step 3. Check for gas leaks. If you smell gas: open windows, leave immediately, do not use any electrical switches or open flames, call the gas company from outside.

Step 4. Wear rubber boots, gloves, and a mask when cleaning up. Floodwater contains sewage, chemicals, and dead animals.

Step 5. Throw away any food that has been in contact with floodwater, even canned food with damaged lids. Throw away any medicines that were touched by floodwater.

Step 6. Do not use tap water until authorities confirm it is safe. Treat all water as described in the water safety guide.

Step 7. Be aware of snakes, insects, and rats that may have moved into your home to escape the water.

MENTAL HEALTH: Feeling anxious, frightened, sad, or unable to sleep after a flood is a completely normal response to trauma. Talk to family, friends, or a community health worker. These feelings are expected and will improve with time and support.